

welcome to the cabins

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Interactive Media III



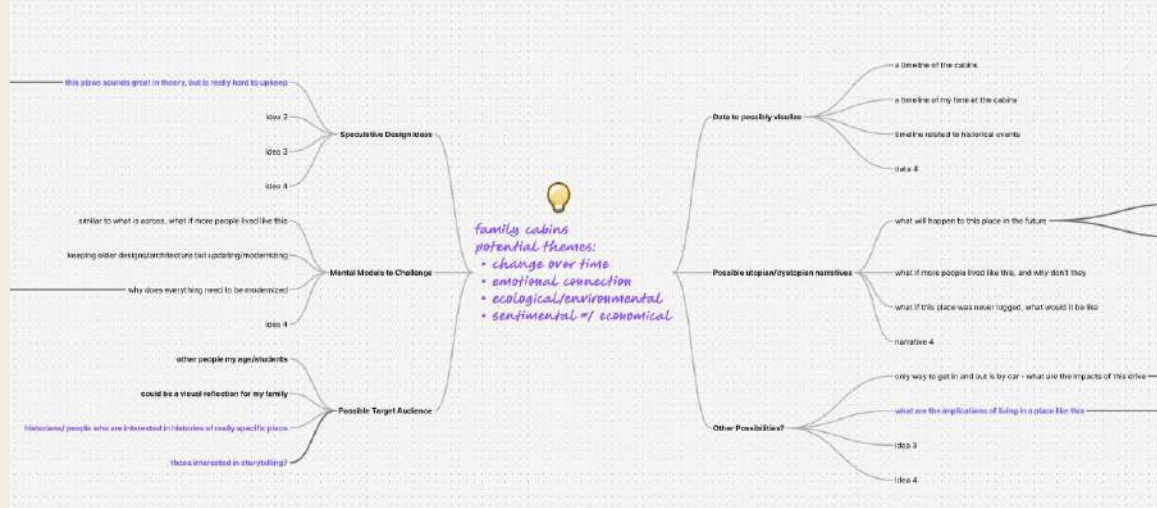
the idea

Coming into this project I was super conflicted on what I wanted to create. I had very little ideas and based on some of my recent projects for other design classes, I wanted to create something different. I was leaning towards making something more personal to me that I would actually enjoy.

From there I landed on creating project about the cabins (Kenjockety) that have been in my family for 100 years. I wanted to tell the story of this place while weaving in my own memories through an interactive map.

the brainstorm

The brainstorming phase was probably one of the places where I got really stuck because wasn't sure exactly where I wanted to take this project. I had too many ideas about what the intent could be. It wasn't until a conversation with the professor that I realized I could just make something much simpler. I was initially thinking about tackling big ideas and issues and didn't realize I really hone on something personal.



comparative analysis

Earlier in the quarter I had seen a graphic design company make an interactive map as the home page of their website. I was intrigued by this. I liked that they created their own little world.

Another site also had a menu that had multiple clickable options. Ultimately I liked this format and thought it would work best for what I intended to create. I needed to show multiple pages of information plus have a way to show and hide each of them. A main navigation hub made sense.



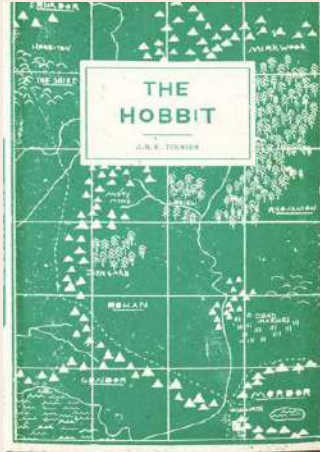
the sketches

Once I settled on the map idea I got to sketching. I know Kenjockety like the back of my hand and had access to a map of the area and each of the parcels of land. It made logical sense to me to have a stylized version of the land and its landmarks. Each point of interest would have a corresponding hidden overlay that would pop out when selected. From these early sketches my structure stayed pretty much that same as what my initial ideas were but with a couple adjustments.



the visual research

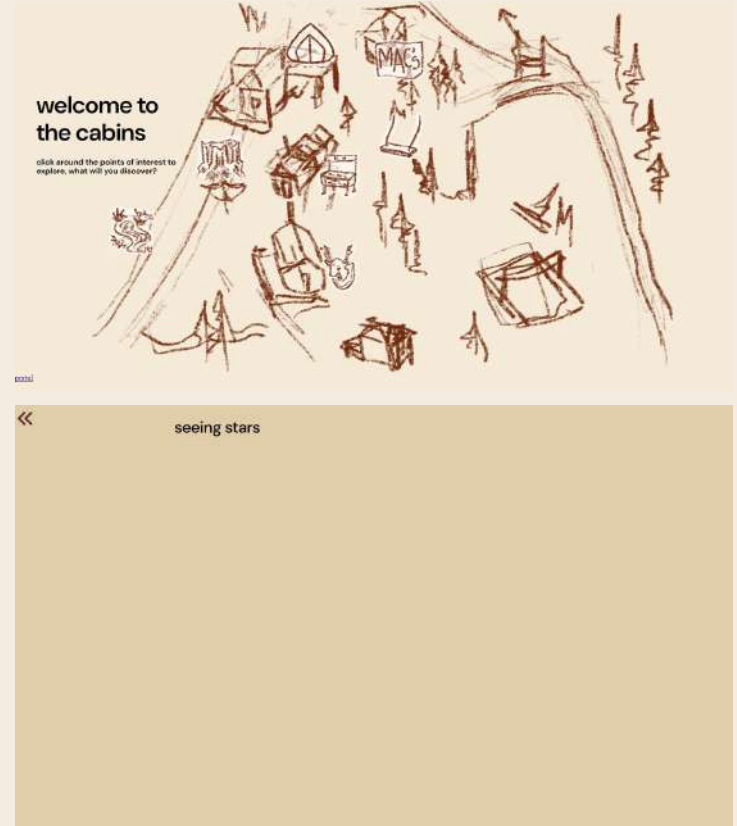
Initially I struggled with the visual look for this project. I didn't want something to be too realistic looking. But I knew that I wanted it to look like a map. So I used some visual research to inform the stylistic direction. I wanted it to be more sketchy



usability testing into version 3

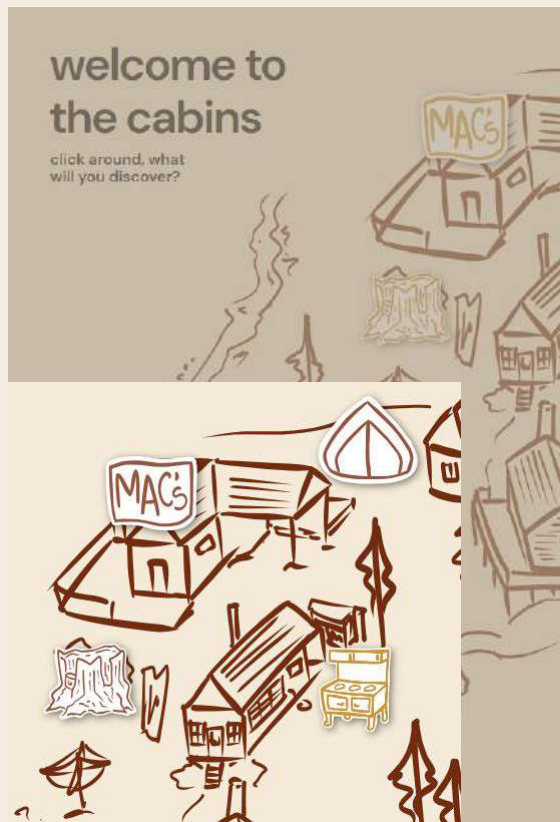
While making my usability test I had realized a couple things about my project. First that I needed a way to differentiate each of the icons from the background. I was hesitant to change the colors as I wanted them to blend with each other a bit. I decided that each of the icons would have a background; making them look like a sticker. I had also received feedback that the overlays should not take up the entire screen.

Up until this point I had done my rough digital sketches with one of the pencil tools and liked the looseness. But decided I would switch to a vector pen to get cleaner lines.



making final changes

And so I cleaned up my drawings significantly along with creating alternate color version when each icon is clicked. The overlay now only takes up 60% of the screen. This gave me a good amount of space for text and imagery. I also included in more visual feedback through cursor changes and movement.



» changing over time

They call the kitchen the heart of the home. I would say the dining cabin is the heart of Kenjockety. The kitchen is always too warm in the evenings and crowded, but it is where all the action happens. Dinner is often an ordeal, especially when you are serving large groups of the family.



As a kid, there were some years where there would easily be fifteen of us up there and dinner would be done in shifts. The kids and then the adults. But when we were all there together, it was loud. There is no other experience like sitting in that cabin eating and talking while watching the forest get darker as the sun dips further between the trees and mountains.



takeaways

Ultimately I happy with how this turned out. There were so many decisions and changes that I made as challenges came up. For example I had to go back and fix my background drawing because text was running into it and I had to change how I structured my layout several times. I was kind of tiring having to constantly go back and adjust my work.

Writing all the text for this was also time consuming along with picking images. I have created a lot of reading with this project for the viewer. I honestly could have included so much more but felt it might be too much. But I think I was able to balance it.

takeaways continued

From this project I feel like I learned a lot about how to tell a story. I didn't want there to be a clear beginning or end and wanted the viewer to choose their own narrative in a way. They can learn as little or as much as they like.

I feel like I could have potentially done something more interesting in terms of my layouts for each of the overlays but honestly, there is only so much I can do with 600 pixels of width. But I do like how I integrated text and imagery together.

But this is a project that I made for myself ultimately. It is for me to reflect on my relationship with this place and by doing so I hope others gain something from it.